



Managed firepower: Before departure, head coach Gautam Gambhir indicated that Jasprit Bumrah is likely to feature in only three of the five Tests, with his workload carefully managed to preserve peak effectiveness. K. R. DEEPAK

Leadership vacuum

India came close to winning in England last time, leading 2-1 before the COVID-delayed fifth Test ended in defeat. In that series, Rohit led the charts with 368 runs, including a century and two fifties, followed by Rahul (315), Cheteshwar Pujara (306), Ravindra Jadeja (287), and Kohli (249). India may not have sealed the series, but its batting unit delivered a performance full of grit and intent.

Now, the captain is young and under pressure. So is the squad.

"There are two ways of looking at this tour. One is we are without our three most experienced players or we got this phenomenal opportunity to do something special for the country," Gambhir was quoted as saying by

bcci.tv. That decision-making begins with Gill's own batting position. He's been used at No.3 recently, but given his struggles in England, a move to No.4 could shield him from the new ball and help him settle into leadership.

"I think Sudharshan and Jaiswal will open the batting (in England) as Sudharshan just looks like a class player to me and technically I think he could do well at Test level," Ponting said on *ICC Review*, adding: "They'll have two pretty young opening batters, so they might look to go for someone that's got a bit more experience at No. 3."

That raises a straight contest between Nair and Rahul for the No.3 spot. "Shubman might end up being

that No.4 player, which will probably make life for him a little bit easier as a captain as well. Not having to be opening or batting at No.3 as a young captain might make it easier," Ponting said.

Bumrah watch

India's challenges aren't limited to batting. Jasprit Bumrah is expected to feature in only three of the five Tests as part of workload management.

That puts pressure on the rest of the pace unit: Mohammed Siraj, Arshdeep Singh, Prasidh Krishna, Akash Deep — none of whom has led an attack in England. All-rounders Shardul Thakur and Nitish Kumar Reddy offer backup, but both looked undercooked in the India A matches.

"The guys have stepped up by

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